Secure two-factor: from text messages to an app, a passkey or a key

Read it on your own, or with the steward on a call. It takes five minutes to read and about ten to act on.

Kind Walkthrough | Changed 2026-11-04 | For Any member of an organisation we serve

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To whom it may concern. This page is written to be handed to any member of an organisation we serve.

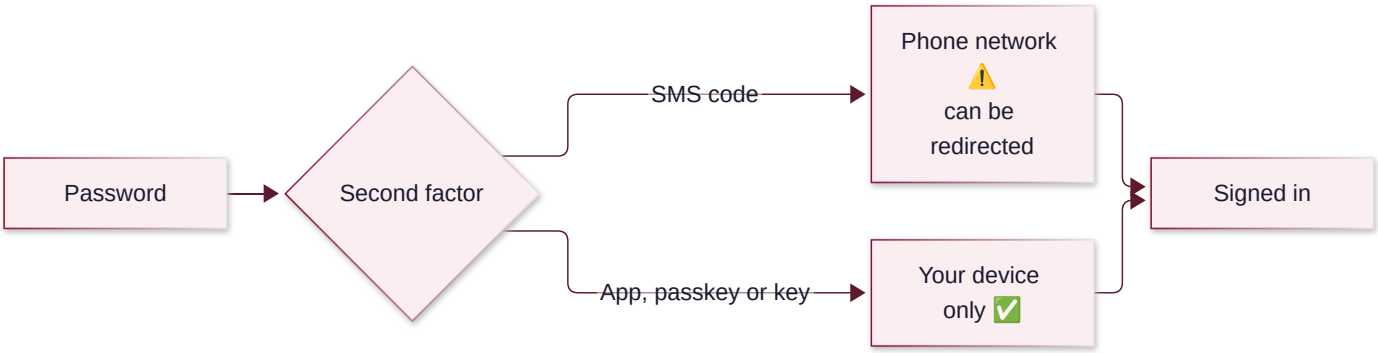
TL;DR

1. **Two-factor** means signing in needs your password *and* something you have, such as your phone or a key.
2. **Text-message (SMS) codes count as two-factor, but they are the weakest kind.** A thief who talks your phone company into moving your number to their SIM ("SIM swap") receives your codes.
3. **Secure methods** are an authenticator app, a passkey, or a security key. None of them travel over the phone network.
4. An organisation can require secure methods only. Before an owner turns that on, everyone switches. Nobody is surprised and nobody is locked out.
5. **You never send anyone your password, a code, or your recovery codes.** Not the steward, not a helper, not an AI.

Why this matters to *you*

Your GitHub account opens the organisation's private rooms: proposals, procedures, sometimes legal papers. If someone takes over your account, they walk in as you. The organisation's own records hold the line only if every door does.

Method	How the code reaches you	Can a stranger intercept it?	Verdict
Text message (SMS)	over the phone network	yes, by SIM swap or a hijacked number	works today, being retired
Authenticator app (Google Authenticator, Microsoft Authenticator, 1Password, Authy…)	generated on your phone, never sent	no	secure
Passkey (your phone's or computer's fingerprint or face unlock)	never leaves your device	no	secure, and the easiest
Security key (YubiKey and similar)	a USB/NFC key you touch	no	secure



Switching, step by step (about ten minutes)

1. Sign in at **github.com** as yourself.
2. Click your picture (top right) → **Settings** → **Password and authentication**.
3. Under **Two-factor methods**, add a secure one:
   - **Passkey:** *Add a passkey* and follow your phone's or computer's prompt. Easiest.
   - **Authenticator app:** *Add* next to "Authenticator app", scan the square code with the app, type the six-digit code it shows.
   - **Security key:** *Add* next to "Security keys" and touch the key.
4. **Save your recovery codes** (download or print them) somewhere only you can reach. They are the way back in if you lose your phone.
5. Only now, remove **SMS/Text message** from the list, and set the new method as **preferred**.
6. Tell the steward, in one line, "switched". No codes, no screenshots of codes.

> ***No two-factor yet at all?*** *Same page,* ***Enable two-factor authentication****. Choose the app or a passkey from the start and skip text messages entirely.*

For owners: turning the requirement on

In **Organisation settings** → **Authentication security**:

- **Require two-factor authentication** removes anyone without two-factor.
- **Only allow secure two-factor methods** excludes text messages.

GitHub's settings page says who would be affected. Read the member list first: `gh api "orgs/<org>/members?filter=2fa_disabled"`. Then ask each person, kindly and by name, before you save. A member who joined before a rule is "grandfathered" only until the owner saves the stricter setting. Give them this page, a date, and a call if they want one.

Suggest a change

Noticed something? Open an issue or a pull request against `main`, changing this page; a steward reads it and a person with the role merges, with a merge commit, so your name stays on it. An AI helper may do all of that up to the merge, signed as the attribution spec says. Not on GitHub? Tell any steward you know, or your helper, in your own words.

Related: JOIN-AN-ORGANIZATION.md (two-factor when you join), ORG-SECURITY-SETTINGS.md (the rest of an owner's security clicks), and SOP-COM-001 *New to GitHub: your first hour* in each organisation's `ops-standard-operating-procedures`. Part of the walkthroughs. Icons: Phosphor duotone (MIT).